credited with bringing together scores of private industries to work for ISRO. Once, when getting the fourth stage engine's columbium nozzle fabricated for PSLV proved difficult, it was Sasi who came with a breakthrough. He discovered a small factory somewhere, which could do the tricky job for us. But the engineer there refused to part with the process. Finally, Sasi got it out of him, reciprocating by making the small-scale industry an ISRO sub-contractor.

Here in Viyyur prison, we were back to reminiscing our association, which went through a few highs and many lows. After a few cell inspections, Sasi's fear of being implicated in a marijuana case was fading. But every time the inspectors came, he stood in reverence, his heart in his mouth. The prison staff, too, had understood by now that we are a bunch of harmless, even meek, men not good at smuggling ganja or trying a jailbreak.

All that changed, however, suddenly with a rumour that Pakistan was planning to airdrop its commandoes in Viyyur jail to rescue me and the other accused in the ISRO spy case.

HOW ISRO TURNED A HILL GREEN

'The peacocks are gone.'

Once the land acquisition was over, we moved a few men to set up an office in Nagercoil and start the process of construction and moving machinery to Mahendragiri. D Subramanian, an instrumentation expert who was part of the Vernon team, was on the forefront of these activities. DS, as we called Subramanian, was a master of logistics management. When it came to engineering, DS's skills extended beyond his core competence of instrumentation.

While working in Vernon, he was primarily in charge of installing transducers in several systems of the rocket engine to gauge different